

restoration of property that had been confiscated from Christians during Diocletian's persecution.

In 324, Constantine became sole ruler of the Roman Empire. Although Christianity was not yet the state religion, under Constantine's rule bishops assumed the rank, dress, and duties of civic authorities. The emperor, who was constantly attended by bishops, gave the bishop of Rome an imperial palace, later called the Lateran Palace—the precursor to the Vatican. He also issued several edicts that gave the Church power to enforce its canons.

Constantine decreed that any Christian in a civil lawsuit with a fellow Christian could transfer the case from a secular court to the arbitration of a bishop. According to the historian Eusebius, Constantine also “put his seal on the decrees of bishops made at synods, so that it would not be lawful for the rulers of provinces to annul what [the bishops] had approved, since the priests of God were superior to any magistrate.” Another imperial decree banned heretics from assembling to worship and handed over their property to the Church. Constantine's defeat of Licinius

“
Let us free our life
from errors and
with the help of the
mercy of God, let us direct it
along the right path.”

Constantine I
Letter to the
Numidian Bishops, 330ce

had taken place at a time when there was a major split in the Church over the nature of Jesus Christ. It began in Alexandria, where a priest named Arius argued that while God the Father had existed for all time, the Son came later and had a beginning in time, and was therefore subordinate to the Father. Alexander, bishop of Alexandria, denounced Arius as a heretic. Yet many bishops and leading Christians supported Arius, and the argument spread

throughout the empire. This quarrel delighted pagans, who exploited it to mock Christian beliefs.

The Council of Nicaea

Constantine, who had no interest in theology, was horrified to see the Church divided and mocked by pagans. To unite the Church, he summoned the first universal synod of bishops, which met at Nicaea, in what is now Turkey, in 325. It was described as an ecumenical council, because bishops came from “the whole world” (*oikoumenikós* in Greek). More than 250 bishops attended what became known as the First Council of Nicaea, which was overseen by Constantine.

The Council rejected Arianism (the views expressed by Arius) and adopted the Nicene Creed, a statement of belief declaring that the Father and Son were “of one substance” and that the Son had been born of the Father “before all ages.” Two dissenting bishops were exiled along with Arius, whose writings were burned. The Council also issued a number of canons on matters including the date of Easter and the organization of the Church's hierarchy. The bishops

Constantine the Great



The first Christian emperor, Constantine I, was born c. 272 CE. He became ruler of the Western Roman Empire in 312 after winning a civil war against the previous emperor, Maxentius (c. 276–312 CE). Before the decisive Battle of the Milvian Bridge, Constantine had a dream in which he was told to decorate the shields of his soldiers with a Christian symbol, the chi-rho (the first two letters of Christ in Greek). Following his victory, Constantine saw the Christian God as his personal patron and did all he could to spread his religion.

In 324, Constantine became sole ruler of the Roman Empire after defeating the Eastern emperor Licinius. In 330, he transferred the imperial capital from Rome to Byzantium, founding a new Christian city, Constantinople (now Istanbul). Constantine had formerly worshipped Sol Invictus, (“unconquered Sun”), the official sun god of the Roman Empire and patron of the army. For a few years after his conversion, Constantine continued to show Sol Invictus on his coins, and was only baptized a Christian on his deathbed in 337.